

TOP GUNS

IN AIR COMBAT OVER NORTH VIETNAM up to the fall of 1968 roughly two North Vietnamese MiGs were downed for every US fighter lost. This ratio did not satisfy the US Navy. A Navy inquiry concluded that pilots were not receiving adequate training in close combat and recommended a new



RETURNED FROM COMBAT

Back on the carrier USS Constellation after shooting down three MiG-17s on a single mission, Lieutenant Randall "Duke" Cunningham (center) treats his colleagues to a graphic account of the day's action.

PHANTOM FIGHTER

Originally designed for the US Navy but also adopted by the USAF, the F-4 Phantom II was an excellent aircraft in its performance and equipment. The ability of the apparently inferior MiGs to hold their own with the F-4s in air combat came as a shock and, in part, led to the founding of the Top Gun school.

TOP GUN BADGES

Modern fighter combat training encourages competition between pilots, hence the name *Top Gun* (seen on the badge, bottom right) for the US Navy's Fighter Weapons School.

training program in which fighter pilots would be pitted against aircraft similar to enemy fighters in realistic air-combat maneuvers. The result was the establishment of the Top Gun school at Miramar Naval Air Station, California, in 1969.

The progress in combat skills that followed was exemplified by US Navy pilot Lieutenant Randall "Duke" Cunningham and his radar officer Lieutenant William Driscoll. They already had two kills to their credit when, on May 10, 1972, their flight of F-4Js was attacked by MiGs over North Vietnam. As Phantom IIs and MiGs fought a turning dogfight, each pilot trying to get on another's tail, Cunningham downed two enemy fighters with Sidewinder missiles. Heading for the coast, he ran into another MiG-17 whose pilot proved aggressive and tenacious, staying with the Phantom II as it maneuvered to shake him off.



By suddenly throttling back and applying his airbrakes, Cunningham finally made the MiG overshoot, got on his tail, and brought him down with a Sidewinder. With five kills, Cunningham and Driscoll were hailed as the first American aces of the Vietnam War.

In the 1970s the Top Gun principle was also adopted by the USAF at its Fighter Weapons School. The use of mock combat as near the real thing as possible, allowing pilots to push their aircraft to the limit, became the norm. It is self-evident with modern fighter pilots that "You fight like you train!"

CELLULOID VERSION

The 1986 film *Top Gun*, set at the US Navy's elite training school, restaged for a new generation the long-established tradition of the fighter pilot as romantic hero. The film was a box-office hit, but the F-14 Tomcats stole the show.

